

Humpback whale

Along with dolphins and porpoises, whales are cetaceans—aquatic mammals that have evolved to swim in the oceans. Together with 14 other species, the humpback whale is a filter feeder—it gulps huge mouthfuls of water and strains out zooplankton (tiny drifting animals) and small swimming fishes.

Crossing oceans

More plankton live in colder waters around the poles, so humpback whales spend their summers feeding in the far north or south. As winter sets in, they migrate toward the warmer waters of the tropics where they breed and give birth to their calves.

Northwest Pacific

In the cold Pacific waters around Russia, whales feed mainly on fishes in shallower waters near the coast, and on zooplankton in deeper water offshore.

Polar front

In the Southern Ocean, many whales gather to feed where cold polar waters meet warmer waters from the north. This zone encircling Antarctica, called the Polar Front, is especially rich in zooplankton.

Baleen plates

Instead of teeth, strips of horny material called baleen hang down from the roof of the whale's mouth. As the whale closes its mouth, water is forced out through the baleen. The frayed, hairy edges of the baleen trap small animals.

